or transport animals for the Bombay troops who were still stranded where they had landed on the shores of the malarial Indus Delta.

Things got worse before they got better. The following week Macnaghten was hurrying to catch up with the army after accompanying the Sikh leader to Lahore, where Fanny and Emily had visited ‘a select number of Mrs Runjeets’. On his way he heard to his horror that General Sir Willoughby Cotton, without any orders, had left the agreed place of rendezvous and was fast heading south, away from Afghanistan, and about to launch an illegal attack on the Sindhi capital of Hyderabad. ‘Cotton is clearly going on a wild goose chase,’ wrote Macnaghten to Simla in desperation. ‘He seems to be travelling by a route which has no road. He will soon, I fear, be in the jungle. If this goes on as it is now doing, what is to become of our Afghan expedition?’ Mirza ‘Ata, who appears to have been attached to Shah Shuja’s Contingent, reported the rumour current in the Sadozai camp that Cotton had wandered so badly astray that it took the miraculous intervention of a saint to get him back on track. ‘The army lost its way in the scrub jungle,’ he wrote, ‘and wandered confused and alarmed for one whole watch, until a white-bearded old man like the prophet Khizr appeared and guided them to their camping grounds by the river.’[20]

Macnaghten sent a series of increasingly desperate notes by camel express, urging Cotton to stop. The General reluctantly agreed to call off the attack, just hours before the assault was due to begin, but only after the amirs had fully submitted to him. As Mirza ‘Ata put it, ‘when these Mirs – an uncouth and subversive lot, always eager to pick a fight – saw waves and waves of British soldiers like a tidal wave, or black clouds of a gathering storm converging both through land and water towards their land, they were intimidated and gave in’.[21] Nevertheless the incident caused a loss of face for the General in front of his troops, who were much looking forward to looting the city that was supposed to contain great riches.

The reunion of Macnaghten and one of his principal commanders was far from a happy one: ‘Sir Willoughby is evidently disposed to look upon His Majesty and myself as mere ciphers,’ Macnaghten complained to Colvin. ‘Any hint from me, however quietly and modestly given, was received with hauteur; and I was distinctly told that I wanted to assume command of the army; that he, Sir Willoughby, knew no superior but Sir John Keane [the Commander-in-Chief], and that he would not be interfered with &c, &c. All this arose out of my requesting 1000 camels for the use of the Shah and his